Best Audiobook Apps: Free, Cheap & Best Apps to Listen to Audiobooks

Audiobooks have changed the way people consume books. Instead of sitting down with a physical book or reading from a screen, you can listen to a novel, biography, business book, self-help guide, or educational title while driving, walking, exercising, cooking, commuting, or relaxing at home.

The growing number of audiobook apps has made listening even more convenient. Some services provide large subscription libraries, some let you purchase individual books, and others allow you to borrow audiobooks from a public library at no direct cost. There are also completely free options focused on public-domain books.

But choosing between all these audiobook apps can be confusing. One service may be excellent for new releases but expensive for occasional listeners. Another may offer thousands of books for free but have limitations on the titles available. Some services let you keep purchased books, while others provide access only while your subscription remains active.



✓✓ CHECK THIS SECRET WEBSITE GIVES 100$ BY FILLING JUST 2 SURVEYS

This guide explains the best audiobook apps, how audiobook services work, where to find free audiobooks, how to choose the cheapest audiobook app for your listening habits, and exactly how to listen to audiobooks on your phone, tablet, computer, or other devices.

What Is an Audiobook App?

An audiobook app is an application that allows you to discover, purchase, borrow, download, or stream spoken versions of books.

Depending on the service, you may find fiction, nonfiction, biographies, romance, mystery, science fiction, business books, self-improvement titles, children's books, educational content, and other categories.

Most modern audiobook apps provide features such as adjustable playback speed, bookmarks, sleep timers, offline downloads, chapter navigation, recommendations, and synchronization across devices.

The biggest difference between services is how you get access to books.

Some use monthly subscriptions and credits. Others provide an unlimited or rotating catalog. Library apps let you borrow digital audiobooks. Store-based apps allow you to purchase individual titles without committing to a monthly subscription.

Understanding these models is important when deciding which audiobook app fits your needs.

Best Audiobook App

There is no single audiobook service that is perfect for every listener. The right choice depends on how often you listen, whether you want new releases, whether you want to own your books, and how much you want to spend.

Here are some of the leading audiobook apps and what makes each one useful.

1. Audible

Audible is one of the most established dedicated audiobook services and offers a very large selection of audiobooks, including popular releases, exclusive productions, original content, and professionally narrated titles.

Its subscription model is particularly useful for people who listen regularly and want access to a large commercial catalog. Depending on the plan, users can access included titles and receive credits that can be used toward eligible audiobooks.

One of the biggest advantages of Audible is the depth of its catalog. If you frequently search for recently released books, popular authors, bestsellers, or specific narrators, a large dedicated audiobook platform can make finding those titles easier.

Audible also supports offline listening, playback-speed controls, bookmarks, and synchronization across supported devices.

For people who listen to several audiobooks every month or frequently want newly released titles, Audible is one of the most important services to consider.

Best for: Large catalogs, new releases, regular listeners, exclusive content, and dedicated audiobook listening.

2. Libby

Libby is one of the most important apps to know if you want to listen to audiobooks without paying for another monthly subscription.

The app connects to participating public libraries and allows eligible library members to borrow digital audiobooks. You can search the available collection, borrow a title, stream it, or download it for offline listening.

The major advantage is obvious: there is no separate audiobook subscription fee. Your access depends on the digital collection provided by your library.

The main limitation is availability. Popular books may have waiting lists, and the selection varies between libraries.

For someone who does not mind waiting for a popular title, Libby can dramatically reduce the cost of audiobook listening.

Best for: Free audiobooks, library members, budget-conscious listeners, and borrowing rather than purchasing books.

3. Spotify

Spotify has expanded beyond music and podcasts to include audiobooks in its Premium ecosystem in supported markets.

This can be convenient for people who already use Spotify because they do not necessarily need another dedicated audiobook application.

The important thing to understand is that audiobook access on Spotify is not the same as unlimited audiobook listening. Current plans and included listening allowances vary, so users should check the terms of their particular subscription before assuming that every audiobook is included. Current 2026 comparisons commonly describe a monthly listening allowance for eligible Premium plans.

Spotify can therefore make sense for casual listeners who already pay for Premium and want to add audiobooks without maintaining another separate subscription.

Best for: Existing Spotify Premium users, casual listeners, music-and-audiobook users, and people who prefer one entertainment app.

4. Libro.fm

Libro.fm offers a different approach to audiobook subscriptions and purchases. It provides access to a large commercial audiobook catalog while connecting audiobook purchases with independent bookstores.

This can appeal to listeners who want a conventional audiobook service but also want their purchases to support independent booksellers.

The service uses a credit-based model for subscribers, while individual audiobooks can also be purchased.

Another important consideration is ownership. Unlike services based purely around temporary catalog access, purchased audiobooks can remain associated with your account after cancellation.

Best for: Audiobook ownership, independent bookstore support, regular listeners, and people looking for an alternative to Amazon-owned services.

5. Everand

Everand takes a broader approach by combining audiobooks with ebooks and other digital reading content.

This can be attractive to people who switch between reading and listening rather than using audiobooks exclusively.

Instead of thinking of the service as only an audiobook store, it can be viewed as a digital reading subscription containing multiple types of content.

The important consideration is that access to subscription content is different from purchasing an audiobook outright. Before subscribing, check which titles are currently included and how access works under the current plan.

Best for: People who use both ebooks and audiobooks and want a broader digital reading subscription.

6. LibriVox

LibriVox is one of the most useful options when the goal is completely free audiobook listening.

The service focuses on public-domain books recorded by volunteers. This means you can find many classic works without paying for a subscription or purchasing individual titles.

The major limitation is the catalog. Because the recordings are based on public-domain material, you should not expect the latest commercial bestsellers.

Narration quality can also vary because recordings are produced by volunteers rather than being uniformly performed by professional narrators.

For classic literature, however, LibriVox can be an excellent free resource.

Best for: Free classic audiobooks, public-domain literature, students, and listeners who do not need new releases.

7. Apple Books

Apple Books is useful for people who want to purchase individual audiobooks rather than subscribe to a dedicated audiobook service.

The app is integrated into Apple's ecosystem, making it convenient for iPhone, iPad, and other supported Apple-device users.

The pay-per-title model can be particularly attractive if you only listen to a few audiobooks each year. Instead of paying every month, you can simply purchase the books you actually want.

Apple Books can therefore be a practical option for occasional listeners who prefer ownership over a subscription catalog.

Best for: Occasional listeners, individual purchases, Apple users, and people who do not want another monthly subscription.

8. Google Play Books

Google Play Books follows a similar individual-purchase approach and can be useful for Android and Google ecosystem users.

You can purchase audiobooks without committing to a dedicated monthly audiobook subscription. This makes it an option for people who only want specific books.

It can also be useful when a particular title is available at a discount or when you prefer managing books through Google's ecosystem.

Best for: Android users, occasional audiobook listeners, individual purchases, and Google users.

9. Hoopla

Hoopla is another library-based digital service that may provide audiobooks at no direct cost to eligible library members.

Its availability depends on whether your library participates and which digital borrowing options it provides.

One useful difference between library services can be how borrowing works. Some systems may have waiting lists for popular titles, while other library platforms can provide immediate access when a title is available under the library's lending arrangement.

Because availability varies, checking your local library's digital services can reveal options you may already have access to.

Best for: Free library audiobooks, instant digital borrowing where available, and budget-conscious listeners.

10. Chirp

Chirp focuses heavily on discounted audiobook deals rather than requiring listeners to maintain a traditional monthly subscription.

This makes it interesting for people who enjoy finding individual books at significantly reduced prices.

The model is simple: watch for a title you want, purchase it when the price is attractive, and build your audiobook collection without paying a recurring subscription.

It is particularly useful for listeners who are patient and willing to wait for sales.

Best for: Cheap audiobook deals, occasional listeners, and people who prefer buying books individually.

Audiobook Apps Compared

Different audiobook apps use different payment and access models.

Audiobook App	Main Model	Best For
Audible	Subscription + credits	Regular listeners and large catalogs
Libby	Library borrowing	Free audiobook listening
Spotify	Premium listening allowance	Existing Spotify users
Libro.fm	Subscription + purchases	Ownership and independent bookstores
Everand	Digital subscription	Audiobooks + ebooks
LibriVox	Free public domain	Classic books

Audiobook App	Main Model	Best For
Apple Books	Individual purchases	Occasional listeners
Google Play Books	Individual purchases	Android and Google users
Hoopla	Library borrowing	Free digital borrowing
Chirp	Discounted individual purchases	Cheap audiobook deals

The important point is that these services are not selling exactly the same product.

A library app is fundamentally different from a subscription service, and a subscription service is different from buying individual audiobooks.

Free Audiobook App

If you are specifically looking for a free audiobook app, start with library services and public-domain collections before signing up for a paid subscription.

Libby for Free Audiobooks

Libby is one of the strongest free options because it provides access to your participating library's digital audiobook catalog. There is no separate audiobook subscription fee, although you need an eligible library card and the title must be available through your library.

The biggest disadvantage is that popular books can have holds.

LibriVox for Free Classics

LibriVox is useful when you want classic books that are in the public domain.

There is no need to subscribe to a commercial audiobook catalog. The trade-off is that the selection focuses on older works and narration quality can vary.

Hoopla for Library Listening

If your library supports Hoopla, it can provide another source of free digital audiobooks.

The exact catalog and borrowing limits depend on the participating library, so availability should be checked through your library.

How to Listen to Audiobooks

If you have never listened to an audiobook before, the process is very simple.

First, choose an audiobook app based on whether you want to borrow, subscribe, or purchase.

Next, create an account if the service requires one. If you are using a library application such as Libby, you will generally need to connect your library account or card.

Search for the book you want to hear.

If it is available, borrow, purchase, or add it to your subscription library depending on the service.

Then open the audiobook and press play.

Most modern audiobook apps provide playback controls that let you pause, rewind, skip forward, change playback speed, set a sleep timer, and move between chapters.

You can also download supported audiobooks for offline listening, which is especially useful when traveling or when you do not want to use mobile data.

How to Listen to Audiobooks on Your Phone

Your smartphone is one of the easiest devices for audiobook listening.

Install your preferred audiobook app from the appropriate app store and sign in.

Search for a book and open its audiobook page. Depending on the platform, you may need to purchase the book, use a subscription credit, borrow it through your library, or select an included title.

Once the audiobook is available in your library, download it if you want offline listening.

Connect your headphones or earbuds and begin listening.

You can listen while walking, commuting, exercising, cleaning, cooking, or relaxing.

Most apps remember your position, so you can stop listening and return to the same chapter later.

How to Listen to Audiobooks for Free

The easiest way to listen to audiobooks for free is usually through your public library.

Start by checking whether your library offers Libby or another digital lending service.

After installing the app, search for your library and sign in using your library credentials.

Search for the audiobook you want.

If it is available, borrow it and start listening.

If another person has already borrowed all available digital copies, you may need to place a hold and wait.

Another option is LibriVox, which focuses on public-domain books. This is especially useful if you enjoy classic literature.

You can also check library services such as Hoopla if your library participates.

How to Listen to Audiobooks Without Internet

Many audiobook apps support offline downloads.

When connected to Wi-Fi, open the audiobook you want and download it to your device.

After the download finishes, you can listen without an active internet connection.

Offline listening is particularly useful for flights, road trips, commuting through areas with poor coverage, or situations where you want to reduce mobile-data usage.

Remember that downloaded content may remain tied to the application that provided it. Library loans can also expire, so downloading a book does not necessarily mean that you permanently own the file.

How to Listen to Audiobooks in the Car

Audiobooks can be a useful way to turn driving time into listening time.

Many modern vehicles support smartphone integration systems that allow compatible audiobook apps to be controlled through the vehicle's display or voice controls.

You can also connect your phone using Bluetooth where supported.

Before driving, select the audiobook and set your desired playback speed. It is better to prepare everything before starting the journey so you are not distracted while driving.

Audiobooks can be particularly useful for long commutes because you can continue the same book over multiple trips.

How to Listen to Audiobooks on a Smart Speaker

Depending on the audiobook service and smart-speaker ecosystem, you may be able to continue listening through a compatible smart speaker.

This can be convenient at home when you do not want to hold your phone.

Voice controls may allow supported services to pause, resume, or control playback.

Compatibility varies between audiobook platforms and devices, so check the current support for your chosen app.

How to Listen to Audiobooks Faster

Most audiobook apps allow you to adjust playback speed.

For example, you may be able to choose a speed slower than normal for difficult material or increase the speed when listening to familiar content.

Listening at a faster speed can reduce the amount of time required to finish a book, but the ideal speed depends on the narrator, subject, and complexity of the material.

For fiction, some listeners prefer a natural narration speed because pacing and character performance are part of the experience.

For nonfiction or educational material, a faster speed may be comfortable for some listeners.

There is no requirement to use the fastest available setting.

Cheapest Audiobook App

The cheapest audiobook app depends on what you mean by cheap.

If you want to spend absolutely nothing, library apps such as Libby can be the most cost-effective option when your library provides the titles you want.

If you want to buy audiobooks individually, discounted services such as Chirp can be attractive because you do not have to maintain a monthly subscription.

If you already pay for another service that includes audiobook listening, such as an eligible Spotify Premium plan, using the included audiobook allowance may be cheaper than adding another dedicated subscription.

For regular listeners, a credit-based subscription can make sense when the books you choose would otherwise cost more individually.

The cheapest option is therefore not necessarily the service with the lowest monthly price. You need to compare how many books you actually listen to and whether you want to own them.

Cheapest Audiobook Apps for Occasional Listeners

If you only finish one or two audiobooks every few months, a monthly subscription may not be necessary.

Instead, consider buying individual titles during sales.

Apple Books and Google Play Books allow individual audiobook purchases, while Chirp is known for discounted audiobook deals.

Libby can also be excellent if you are willing to borrow books rather than own them.

For occasional listeners, avoiding a subscription that goes unused can save more money than finding a slightly cheaper monthly plan.

Cheapest Audiobook Apps for Heavy Listeners

Heavy listeners have different needs.

If you finish several audiobooks every month, purchasing every title individually can become expensive.

A subscription or credit-based service may provide better value, depending on the titles you listen to.

Audible, Libro.fm, Everand, and eligible Spotify plans use different approaches to audiobook access, so compare their current catalogs and terms rather than looking only at the advertised monthly price.

A listener who wants to own individual books may prefer a credit or purchase model. Someone who mainly wants access to a large rotating selection may prefer a catalog subscription.

Free vs Paid Audiobook Apps

The difference between free and paid audiobook apps is not simply quality.

Free library apps can provide excellent commercial audiobooks because the library has licensed them for borrowing.

The limitation is availability.

A paid service generally gives you more immediate access to popular titles, although the exact catalog and ownership terms depend on the provider.

Public-domain services such as LibriVox are completely different because their catalogs focus on works that are available in the public domain.

The best choice depends on whether you prioritize cost, selection, immediate availability, or ownership.

Audiobook Subscription vs Buying Books

There are two major ways to think about audiobook access.

A subscription gives you ongoing access to a service's catalog or credits for purchasing eligible books.

Buying a book individually means you pay specifically for the title you want.

Subscriptions can be useful for regular listeners who consume audiobooks frequently.

Individual purchases can be better for occasional listeners who do not want recurring charges.

Before choosing, calculate how many audiobooks you realistically finish each month.

Do You Own Audiobooks After Cancelling a Subscription?

This depends entirely on the service.

Some platforms allow you to retain access to audiobooks you purchased or acquired through credits, while other subscription catalogs provide access only while your membership remains active.

Library audiobooks are borrowed rather than owned and will expire at the end of the loan period.

Spotify's included audiobook access is also different from purchasing a title outright.

This distinction is important because a low monthly price does not necessarily mean you are building a permanent audiobook collection.

Always check the provider's current ownership and cancellation terms before subscribing.

Best Audiobook Apps for Beginners

If you are listening to your first audiobook, do not overcomplicate the process.

Libby is a great starting point if you have a participating library card and want to test audiobooks without paying.

Audible is worth considering if you want access to a broad commercial catalog and popular releases.

Spotify can be convenient if you already use Premium and want to experiment with audiobooks.

Apple Books or Google Play Books can make sense if you only want to purchase one particular book.

The best beginner option is often the one that lets you start listening without forcing you to build a complicated system.

Best Audiobook Apps for Students

Students can use audiobooks for more than entertainment.

Audiobooks can be useful for supplementary reading, biographies, classic literature, language learning, and books related to personal development or academic subjects.

Library apps such as Libby can help students access books without adding another subscription expense.

For public-domain classics, LibriVox can also be useful.

However, students should check whether an audiobook matches the required edition of a textbook or assigned reading. An audiobook version may not include diagrams, footnotes, tables, or other information contained in the print or digital edition.

Best Audiobook Apps for Fiction

Fiction listeners often care about narration quality as much as the book itself.

A talented narrator can add different voices, pacing, emotion, and character interpretation to a story.

Audible, Libro.fm, Spotify, Apple Books, and other commercial platforms provide access to professionally narrated fiction across many genres.

For older classics, LibriVox can be a free alternative, although narration quality varies considerably between recordings.

If narration matters to you, listen to the sample before committing to a long audiobook.

Best Audiobook Apps for Nonfiction

Nonfiction audiobooks can be particularly convenient because they can be consumed while doing other activities.

Business books, biographies, history, psychology, personal development, and other nonfiction categories are widely available across major audiobook platforms.

For complicated nonfiction, however, listening speed matters.

You may want to slow the narration down or pause periodically to think about important ideas.

Some listeners also prefer having the ebook or physical book available so they can reference charts, quotes, or other visual information.

Audiobook App Features to Look For

Playback Speed

Speed controls let you customize narration to your preference.

Sleep Timer

A sleep timer is useful if you listen before bed and do not want the audiobook playing all night.

Offline Listening

Downloads allow you to listen without an internet connection.

Bookmarks

Bookmarks are useful for saving interesting passages or returning to important sections.

Chapter Navigation

Clear chapter controls make it easier to move through longer books.

Progress Synchronization

Synchronization allows you to continue listening from another supported device.

Car Integration

Compatibility with vehicle systems can make audiobook listening safer and more convenient while parked or when using supported hands-free controls.

Listening Statistics

Some apps provide information about listening time and progress, which can be motivating for regular listeners.

How to Choose the Best Audiobook App

Start with your listening frequency.

If you listen to one audiobook every few months, consider free library borrowing or individual purchases.

If you listen every week, a subscription may provide better value.

If you want the latest commercial releases, focus on services with deep commercial catalogs.

If you mainly enjoy classic literature, a free public-domain service may be enough.

If you want to own your books, pay attention to the purchase model.

If you already pay for Spotify, check whether its current audiobook allowance meets your needs.

If you have a library card, check Libby and other library services before paying for anything.

This approach can save money while still giving you access to a large selection of books.

Common Audiobook Listening Mistakes

One common mistake is subscribing to several audiobook services at the same time.

Unless you are a very heavy listener, multiple subscriptions can quickly become unnecessary.

Another mistake is choosing an audiobook based only on its title without listening to the narration sample.

Narration style can have a huge impact on whether you enjoy a book.

Another mistake is buying books faster than you can listen to them. A large digital library may look impressive, but unused subscriptions and impulse purchases can become expensive.

It is also important to understand the difference between borrowing, streaming, and owning.

A book that is available in a subscription catalog may not remain available forever, while a library loan will eventually expire.

Frequently Asked Questions

What is the best audiobook app?

The best audiobook app depends on your listening habits. Audible is designed for dedicated audiobook listeners and offers a large commercial catalog. Libby is an excellent option for free library borrowing, while Spotify can be convenient for eligible Premium subscribers. Libro.fm focuses on

audiobook purchases and independent bookstores, and Everand combines audiobooks with ebooks and other digital content.

What are the best audiobook apps?

Popular audiobook apps include Audible, Libby, Spotify, Libro.fm, Everand, Apple Books, Google Play Books, LibriVox, Hoopla, and Chirp. Each uses a different access or payment model.

What is the best free audiobook app?

Libby is one of the strongest free options if you have access to a participating library. LibriVox is useful for free public-domain audiobooks, while Hoopla can provide free digital borrowing through participating libraries.

What is the cheapest audiobook app?

There is no single cheapest option for every listener. Libby can provide audiobooks at no separate subscription cost through a library, while LibriVox offers public-domain books for free. For paid listening, discounted individual-purchase services can be cheaper for occasional listeners, while subscriptions can make more sense for heavy listeners.

How do I listen to audiobooks?

Install an audiobook app, search for a title, then borrow, purchase, or access it through your subscription. Open the book and press play. Most apps also provide playback-speed controls, bookmarks, sleep timers, and offline downloads.

How can I listen to audiobooks for free?

Check whether your public library supports Libby or Hoopla. You can also use LibriVox for public-domain audiobooks. Availability depends on your library and the specific title.

Can I listen to audiobooks without internet?

Yes. Many audiobook apps allow supported titles to be downloaded for offline listening. Download the book while connected to Wi-Fi and then listen without an active internet connection.

Can I listen to audiobooks in the car?

Yes. Depending on your vehicle and phone, compatible audiobook apps can work through Bluetooth or supported vehicle smartphone-integration systems. Prepare your audiobook before driving and use hands-free controls where available.

Are audiobooks cheaper than physical books?

It depends on the title and how you access it. Library borrowing can make audiobooks free, while subscriptions can reduce the effective cost for frequent listeners. Individual audiobook purchases can sometimes cost more or less than physical editions depending on sales and pricing.

Do audiobook apps require a subscription?

No. Some apps use subscriptions, but others allow individual purchases, library borrowing, or free public-domain listening.

Can I keep audiobooks after cancelling a subscription?

It depends on how you obtained the audiobook and the provider's terms. Purchased titles may remain accessible, while subscription-only catalog content can become unavailable after cancellation.

Is Libby completely free?

Libby does not charge a separate audiobook subscription fee. You need an eligible library account, and the audiobook must be available through your library's digital collection.

Is Spotify good for audiobooks?

Spotify can be useful for people who already use an eligible Premium plan and want audiobook access alongside music and podcasts. However, audiobook listening is subject to the current plan's catalog and usage terms rather than being unlimited access to every audiobook.

Final Thoughts

The best audiobook app depends on what you want from your listening experience.

If you want a dedicated commercial audiobook service with a large selection, Audible is one of the major options to consider. If your priority is saving money, check Libby and other library services before paying for a subscription. LibriVox is useful for free public-domain classics, while Hoopla can provide another library-based option where available.

Spotify can be convenient for people who already have an eligible Premium subscription. Libro.fm offers an alternative purchase and subscription model with independent bookstore support, while Everand is attractive to people who consume both ebooks and audiobooks.

For occasional listeners, individual-purchase services such as Apple Books and Google Play Books can make more sense than maintaining a monthly subscription. Discount-focused services such as Chirp can also be useful when you are willing to wait for audiobook deals.

The answer to how to listen to audiobooks is ultimately simple: choose the access model that fits your habits, find a title, download or stream it, and start listening. The bigger decision is whether you want to borrow, subscribe, or buy.

If your goal is a free audiobook app, start with your library and public-domain sources. If you want the cheapest audiobook app, compare your actual monthly listening habits rather than looking only at subscription prices. And if you want the best audiobook app, focus on catalog availability, narration quality, playback features, ownership, and overall convenience.

You do not necessarily need several subscriptions. For many listeners, one paid service combined with a free library app can provide enough variety while keeping audiobook costs under control.